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Fatherhood, marriage … and divorce

As a 22-year-old on the cusp of an international cricketing career, fatherhood was the last thing I wanted. My relationship with my son, however, has gone from strength to strength. Unfortunately, my marriage a decade later was the exact opposite …

Fatherhood

Not everyone knows this, but I have a son called Rashard. It's not a secret; it's just that I became a father at a very young age and my relationship with my son's mom soured after I found out she was pregnant. This part of my life hasn't been given too much attention in the press, for which everyone concerned is grateful. However, I've got to a point in my life where I'd like to tell people about my relationship with my son, a youngster I love very much. Our relationship didn't start off too well, but I'm now happy and grateful to have a healthy bond with a son of whom I'm very proud.

I met Liesl Fuller in my last year at school in 1992. It was Nuffield Week – the provincial schools cricket tournament – which was being held in Stellenbosch that year. Liesl was still at school as well. She was five years younger than me, and on holiday with her parents from Joburg. Nothing happened in those early years – she was obviously pretty young – but we kept in touch. After I left school and started playing cricket full time, I'd see her whenever I was in Joburg. Gradually things got more serious and by 1996 we were sleeping together.

Then one night, later that year, she phoned me at my parents' house, where I was still living. By now I was 22 and Liesl 17. 'Listen,' she said, 'I'm three months pregnant. I've been sick … I thought I had the flu or something.'